

05 / 05 DELIVERABLE · THE INSTRUMENT

When-to-Hire Instrument

Not a headcount calculator. A router — it tells you when strain in the analyst function means *hire*, versus *automate*, *redesign*, or *fix the corpus*. This is Michele's instrument.

Status Capacity feed live · delivery-log feed ships with Deliverable 1 Owner Michele Curran, COO

Today the hiring call is gut. This turns *"I feel like we need someone"* into *"here's the trend line, here's the threshold we crossed, here's why it's a hire and not a tool."* Defensible upward, built in peacetime, on purpose.

"Metrics in place before we trigger hiring."

MICHELE CURRAN, FRAMING THE BRIEF

One router, two feeds

FEED 1 · CAPACITY

Daily 3-tap check-in — perceived load, why, and who's working what. Live today.

THE ROUTER

Automate → Redesign → Fix corpus
→ Hire, walked in that order, always.

FEED 2 · DELIVERY

Per-report facts — cycle time, on-cadence rate, rework rounds. Ships with Deliverable 1.

Two feeds because they capture different things at different natural moments. Capacity captures how the team *feels*, daily — three questions, no more, so the response rate stays protected. Delivery facts crystallize once, at the moment a report actually ships. Neither is a second job; both ride along on work that was happening anyway.

The five signals

SIGNAL	WHAT IT IS	FEED
WIP per analyst	Active clients/tasks in flight per person — the "full hands" ceiling	Capacity
Perceived load	Daily 1–10 self-rating plus a reason — the earliest warning, since people feel strain before metrics show it	Capacity
Cycle time	Period start to delivered — a slow climb here shows up weeks before a due date is actually missed	Delivery
On-cadence rate	% of reports delivered by their due date	Delivery
Rework rounds	Revision rounds before client acceptance — the team's #1 named pain, and usually a corpus gap, not a headcount gap	Delivery

Five signals, not twenty — a COO should read this in 30 seconds or the instrument is wrong. Every threshold below is a v1 *seed*: Michele's number to adjust as real data comes in, not a fixed formula handed down from outside.

The router chain

A 1990s tool asks "slammed → hire?" This walks the chain in order — hire is the last branch, never the first reflex.

01 Automate?

Is the strained step repetitive and rules-based? Evidence: the same manual step named repeatedly in check-ins and delivery notes. → Route: automate it — data sync, formatting, first-draft work.

02 Redesign?

Is the *workflow* the bottleneck — not capacity, not quality? Evidence: on-cadence rate below threshold, or cycle time trending up while still narrowly making due dates — and the slowdown clusters at one identifiable handoff, client, or process. A slowdown spread evenly across the whole team, alongside elevated capacity signals, is a capacity problem, not a redesign — it's let through to the hire check instead. → Route: fix the handoff, not the headcount.

03 Fix the corpus?

Is quality inconsistent because the standard still lives in someone's head? Evidence: rework rounds meaningfully frequent, and mostly tagged as a corpus-alignment cause rather than a one-off client ask. → Route: fill the gap in the standard, not the roster.

04 Hire

Only once 1–3 are ruled out *portfolio-wide* — not just "a signal exists somewhere." Capacity has to be sustainably maxed across the team, not one person; a genuine redistribution option has to be checked and ruled out first; and there has to be enough real data behind the read to trust it. → This is the defensible hire: the ruled-out trail above is the evidence Michele takes upward.

The output is never "hire: yes/no." It's "here's what crossed, here's why the answer is this route, here's the evidence trail."

What's live today

This chain is real and usable *by hand*, right now — it doesn't wait on any dashboard code. Michele or Chii can walk it monthly with the capacity dashboard and the delivery logs open side by side, the moment each has a few weeks of data. Wiring it into the dashboard automates the arithmetic; it isn't what makes the router real — the instrument was never meant to wait on a piece of software to be the real thing.

What Michele sees

- **Daily, live today:** a 10:00 summary — team average, everyone's load and reason, sorted most-loaded first, flags for anyone over the line.
- **Anytime, live today:** the dashboard — tiles, trend, and plain-language signal detail.
- **Monthly, live today, by hand:** the full router line — *"Rework on Client X crossed threshold in week 6 → routes to a corpus fix, not a hire."* Fifteen minutes to write, thirty seconds to read, defensible in one line.
- **Once the dashboard build lands (60–90 days):** the same line, generated automatically instead of hand-assembled. Convenience, not new capability — the capability is already there.

Baselines & calibration

Thresholds can't be known upfront — v1 sets them, reality sharpens them. That's said plainly on purpose; it's the method, not a weakness. Trust is gated on *completed cycles*, not calendar time, because a weekly client and a monthly client reach a trustworthy baseline at very different speeds:

CADENCE	TIME TO A TRUSTWORTHY BASELINE
Weekly	~3 weeks (3 completed cycles)
Bi-weekly	~6 weeks
Monthly	~3 months

Until a client crosses its own bar, its numbers are read qualitatively alongside broader patterns rather than trusted in isolation. Every threshold recalibrates quarterly with Michele against real distributions — living numbers, not one-time settings.

Hard rules

- **Owned and portable.** Signal data lives in the corpus and an exportable database — no vendor lock on the data itself.
- **Runs on the stack already in use.** Drive, Telegram, the tools the team already touches.
- **Five signals, not twenty.** Readable in 30 seconds, or it's wrong.
- **A router, not a binary.** Never a bare hire/no-hire — always the evidence trail behind it.
- **Feeding it is never a second job.** Three taps a day, one row opened per scheduled cycle, updated at ship, finalized at acceptance. That's the entire cost.

The lines to hold

Hire is the last resort on the router, not the first reflex.

This tells you why it's a hire, not just that it's a hire — that's what you defend upward.

The vault is yours. The lens is rented.

v1 sets baselines. Reality sharpens the thresholds.